

Chapter 88-3

Xu Qingzhu sat quietly. Only when Liang Shi was nearly done tying her hair did she tease, "Teacher Liang, with this outfit today, are you planning to walk the red carpet?"

She had a habit of pausing when she spoke, and that pause made her smile deepen. Her slender, fair hand lifted and landed on Liang Shi's waist, casually giving it a light pinch.

But Liang Shi winced in pain. She looked down at Xu Qingzhu, her hand naturally grasping hers. "What are you doing?"

Xu Qingzhu teased, "Your waist is really slender."

"Can't compare to yours." Liang Shi said as she set her hand down, explaining, "I didn't have to work today, so I did my makeup at home."

"Really beautiful." Xu Qingzhu praised without reservation. "You've got that female celebrity vibe now."

Liang Shi: "..."

She returned to her seat and raised her hand to brush the long hair hanging in front of her to her back. Even this casual gesture appeared enchanting and captivating.

"Teacher Xu, are you complimenting me?" Liang Shi asked very sincerely.

Xu Qingzhu nodded, raised an eyebrow, and smiled with curved lips. "Why wouldn't I be?"

"I misunderstood then." Liang Shi said, "Every time Teacher Xu compliments someone, it's hard to tell."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She glanced at Liang Shi, her voice slowing down, her pace unhurried. "Likewise."

"Such a nice atmosphere." Liang Shi was the first to call a truce. "Let's just eat properly."

"I didn't say anything." Xu Qingzhu's gaze happened to sweep across Liang Shi's collarbone. "Teacher Liang, how many coins can you balance on your collarbone?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Want to try?" Liang Shi said provocatively.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. "We'll try when we get home."

Liang Shi lowered her head and chuckled softly, but her hair suddenly fell forward, nearly landing on her plate. Xu Qingzhu reached out to brush it back for her and asked, "Why don't you tie it up? Can't female celebrities tie their hair when eating?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Do all you female CEOs have to tie your hair up when eating?" Liang Shi retorted.

Xu Qingzhu froze for two seconds, then nodded. "Yes, and it's my wife who ties it for me."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi's ears suddenly turned bright red.

She pinched her own earlobe. "Alright, Teacher Xu, let's eat."

In this round of passive-aggressive banter, she had lost.

It was mainly Xu Qingzhu's fault... she was too formidable!

Liang Shi comforted herself internally—these businesspeople would stop at nothing!

Their tactics were extremely despicable!

Xu Qingzhu smiled and raised her hand to ask a server for a hair tie.

She slipped the hair tie onto her finger, her tone teasing. "Miss Celebrity, do I have the honor of tying your hair?"

Liang Shi: "...Thank you, President Xu. The honor is mine."

Xu Qingzhu stood up, walked over to her side, and quickly finished tying her hair.

But the moment she finished, she suddenly leaned down, her arm resting on Liang Shi's shoulder. She tugged Liang Shi's off-shoulder dress up slightly to cover her shoulders a bit more. Her lips drew close to Liang Shi's ear, her breath spilling entirely into Liang Shi's ear, making her whole body feel hot and tingly.

To others, it looked like she was kissing her ear.

But Xu Qingzhu whispered to her, "Being able to tie Teacher Liang's hair is my honor."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her heartbeat accelerated in an instant. She couldn't even hear the elegant cello music in the restaurant anymore—she could only hear the sound of her own heartbeat.

Thump—thump—

Xu Qingzhu returned to her seat and smiled with curved lips. "Eat up."

Liang Shi quickly lowered her eyes, not daring to look anymore.

The elegant cello music soon disappeared, replaced by instrumental music playing through the speakers. The romantic atmosphere instantly diminished by half.

When the server came by again, Liang Shi politely inquired, "Where's your cellist?"

The server apologized, "Sorry, miss. The cellist had something at school and left. The replacement pianist won't arrive for another half hour."

Liang Shi said helplessly, "Alright."

Other customers were also asking about this one after another. Xu Qingzhu finished the steak on her plate and suddenly asked, "Do you really want to hear cello music?"

Liang Shi was startled. "Huh?"

Before she could say "Not really," Xu Qingzhu had already stood up and removed her suit jacket, revealing the white shirt underneath.

It was a loose fit that made her look even more slender. She undid her shirt cuffs, pulled down her hair tie, and unfastened the top button that had been buttoned all the way up, revealing a silver necklace and her delicate collarbone.

Liang Shi was stunned. The words she had prepared took a turn and were swallowed back. Almost without thinking, she blurted out, "How many coins can you balance on your collarbone?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu's hand paused while rolling up her sleeve. She smiled lightly. "We'll see tonight when we get back."

Her words were flirtatious and enticing. Though her voice was still cool and clear, it sounded soft and lingering, stirring one's heart and mind.

Xu Qingzhu turned and walked to the counter, lightly tapping her knuckles on it, negotiating something unknown with the staff.

Then she walked toward the idle cello.

Xu Qingzhu sat there, positioned the cello, and gently drew the bow across the strings. A melodious cello piece began to fill the restaurant, even more soothing than before.

Liang Shi didn't know much about the cello, so she didn't know what piece she was playing.

But the melody was sometimes soaring, sometimes deep, sometimes like ten thousand galloping horses, sometimes like a babbling stream.

As the saying goes: experts see the technique, while laymen watch the spectacle¹.

As a layman, Liang Shi simply felt the spectacle was wonderful.

To her ears, Xu Qingzhu's performance was much better than the previous one.

Xu Qingzhu sat within the spotlight, naturally exuding a quiet and gentle beauty that left people mesmerized.

When the piece ended, Xu Qingzhu set the cello upright beside her and bowed with the bow in hand to express her thanks. Applause erupted throughout the restaurant.

At the very front of the performance stage stood a microphone. Only after placing the cello properly did Xu Qingzhu walk to the microphone. She looked toward Liang Shi: "I dedicate this piece to Miss Liang. Thank you, Miss Liang, for tonight's dinner."

Footnotes:

¹ **Experts see the technique, while laymen watch the spectacle (內行看門道，外行看熱鬧):** A Chinese proverb meaning that experts can appreciate the skill and subtleties behind something, while non-experts can only enjoy the surface-level entertainment or excitement without understanding the deeper craft involved.